Collective responsibility

It had to be such—because the alternative would imply a degree of collective responsibility, and would implicate people like Ayelet Shaked, a prominent member of the Jewish Home party. She strongly condemned Abu Khdair's murder, denouncing his killers as "heinous". "Murderers who murder children in cold blood, youth, women and innocent men, should spend the rest of their lives in prison," she said. Less than twenty-four hours earlier, though, Shaked had told her supporters that the "entire Palestinian population is the enemy." An incendiary statement on her Facebook page—described as an "unpublished speech" written more than a decade earlier by Uri Elitzur, a onetime adviser to Netanyahu—argued "that the Palestinian population has declared war on us, and we must reply with war." (The post has since been deleted, but the text was preserved on various Israeli websites.)

> Behind every terrorist stand tens of men and women, without whom he could not engage in terrorism… they are all enemy fighters, and their blood shall be on their heads. Now this also includes the mothers of the martyrs, who send them to hell with flowers and kisses. They need to follow their sons; nothing would be more just than that. They need to go, and also the physical homes in which they raised their sons. Otherwise, they will raise more little snakes there.[18]

It is hard to interpret this as anything but a call for mass murder, though Shaked later accused critics of misinterpreting this "sober, legally-minded discussion" and dismissed them as "militant leftists".[19]

Both sets of murders plumbed unspeakable depths. No circumstances can justify plucking teenagers off the street and killing them. Even so, it bears noting that the Israeli teenagers—two of them minors—were studying in what is still effectively a conflict zone, a territory that the Israeli supreme court has described as being under "belligerent occupation". Their parents sent them to the West Bank, and their government supported their presence there.

Some argued that Netanyahu himself had played a role in stoking tensions. That summer Israeli journalists found themselves briefly tied up in an incongruous debate about the overlap between literary allusion and politics. At the centre of the discussion was a series of tweets sent by the prime minister himself. Had he been calling for revenge? Hours after the bodies of the Israeli teenagers were found, he began his tweet with a quote from the work of Chaim Bialik, a Ukrainian-born Jew who eventually